

Hello my name is Kevin Lopez. I am a junior transfer, and my biggest financial struggle is paying for gas money. I commute to Cal Poly for four days a week for school days and sometimes seven days a week if the clubs I am participating in need to meet up for the other free days. My commute to Cal Poly is around 39 – 50 minutes depending on the traffic. I travel from Santa Maria where I have been living with my parents since I was a kid. I thought my decision to live off campus would save a big amount of money. While I am still saving a good amount of money by not moving out. I did not expect to pay so much for gas. The car I am using is old, so the mpg is not the best, so I am currently spending between \$80 - \$100 a week for gas to travel from Santa Maria to Cal Poly. That's about \$500 I am spending on gas per month, and this affected my academics a lot. The first reason is clubs. Some of the clubs I am attending require meeting up during the days that I don't have classes. There are times that I have to skip those important meetings just to save gas for more important or mandatory days like for the days I have classes. This means that I can miss important workshops, alumni chats, and networking opportunities for those clubs. Another reason is that I have two days of the week where I only have one class for those days. That class is only 50 minutes long. Driving to Cal Poly for 50 minutes and heading back home after 50 minutes is a waste of money. To compensate for that I pretty much stay on the campus the whole day studying at the library or being in the rec center. This sounds good academically, but I could do both studying and doing activities for much cheaper where I live. The only thing I would be missing for that day if I decided to save gas money is the 50 minutes of lecture. So, there are times where I want to skip the class for those days to save \$15 worth of gas. Getting this scholarship will greatly help me financially and academically because I won't have to worry about sacrificing not going to school for specific days just to save gas for possibly two months.